

THE MICHAEL THORNE SERIES - BOOK SEVEN

The Badge and the Blade

A Psychological Crime Thriller

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READING SAMPLE

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About this reading sample

This reading sample contains a continuous excerpt from the beginning of *The Badge and the Blade*. It is based on the edition identified on the cover. The text below is drawn from the manuscript and is not the complete book.

Excerpt length: approximately 4,960 words.

PROLOGUE THE VERDICT ROOM

* * *

Martin Keene had spent thirty-four years entering rooms because a badge told other people he belonged there.

The last room opened for him without one.

It was on the third floor of the old police training annex, beyond a corridor scheduled for demolition and a stairwell that smelled of wet concrete. The department had stopped using the building six years earlier. A private contractor now stored broken desks, obsolete radios and courtroom furniture there until the city decided whether any of it was worth moving.

Martin arrived at 3:47 on a Thursday afternoon.

He had told his daughter he was going to the pharmacy.

The lie was smaller than the envelope in his coat and older than the fear that brought him there.

The envelope had appeared beneath his apartment door that morning.

No stamp.

No return address.

Inside were twelve pages from a case Martin had tried not to remember in sequence.

People v. Darius Kemp.

Armed robbery.

Unlawful possession.

A gun recovered beneath the driver's seat of a Buick registered to Kemp's cousin.

Martin had been the arresting officer.

The first page of the packet accused him of planting the gun.

That was false.

The seventh page showed a second camera angle from a grocery store across the street. Martin had obtained it two days after the arrest and held it for another seventy-two hours before placing it into evidence.

That was true.

The video showed someone else leaving the Buick twenty minutes before Martin stopped Kemp.

It did not show who placed the gun inside.

It created doubt Martin had not wanted the prosecutor to see before the preliminary hearing.

He had told himself the delay changed nothing because Kemp had assaulted the store owner during a different incident three weeks earlier.

He had told himself a dangerous man did not become innocent because one camera complicated one charge.

He had told himself many things that sounded better before retirement.

The final page of the packet contained one sentence.

THE ORIGINAL RECORD WILL BE AVAILABLE AT 4:15.

Below it was a photograph of Courtroom Three inside the abandoned annex.

The door stood open.

Martin reached it at 3:52.

It was closed now.

A plastic evidence seal crossed the handle, but the seal carried no number and no initials. It was theatre made from the language of procedure.

Martin photographed it with his phone.

No signal reached the third floor.

He stepped back towards the stairwell.

A speaker clicked above the door.

"You came for the original."

The voice was neither masked nor familiar enough for certainty.

Martin looked towards the ceiling camera.

Its red light was off.

"Who are you?"

"The person who read past the first page."

Martin kept one hand inside his coat.

Not on a weapon.

He had surrendered his service pistol when his licence expired and had never replaced it. His hand closed around the envelope instead.

"If you have evidence, give it to the court."

"Which court?"

"The appellate court. The conviction-integrity unit. Federal court if you think the department touched it."

"All three received versions."

"Then this is over."

"It was over for Darius Kemp eleven years ago."

Martin felt the old instinct rise before the old shame.

Assess the exits.

Find the person controlling the room.

Do not answer the accusation inside the question.

The stairwell door had closed behind him. The crash bar no longer moved.

A second door stood at the far end of the corridor, marked STORAGE. A green light glowed above it.

Available exit.

Too obvious.

"Kemp was convicted on three counts," Martin said. "The gun was one."

"You delayed the second camera."

"Yes."

The word entered the corridor without qualification.

Martin had avoided saying it for eleven years.

It did not kill him.

"Why?" the voice asked.

"Because I thought he did it."

"The gun charge?"

Martin looked at the false seal across Courtroom Three.

"I thought he was dangerous."

"That was not the question."

"No."

Something moved behind the narrow wired window in the courtroom door.

A person crossed from left to right.

Dark clothes.

Gloves.

No face remained in the glass long enough to record.

Martin moved towards the stairwell again.

The speaker said, "What fact made you stop reading?"

He knew the answer.

Not the gun.

Not the camera.

Kemp's prior assault report.

The photographs of the shopkeeper's broken jaw.

The fact that made every later uncertainty feel like a technicality.

"He hurt someone," Martin said.

"So the first true fact allowed the false conclusion."

"It allowed me to make a bad decision. It did not plant a gun."

"Correct."

The agreement frightened him more than accusation would have.

The courtroom door opened inward.

No one stood behind it.

A retired police badge rested on the judge's bench beneath a white track light.

Martin recognised the scratched number before he recognised the badge as his.

He had placed it inside a cedar box in his bedroom after the administrative revocation hearing. His daughter had helped him carry the box when he moved apartments.

Below the badge lay a printed copy of the planted-gun allegation.

Below the allegation lay the grocery-store image that complicated it.

Below the image lay a knife.

Plain black handle.

Four-inch blade.

The order was deliberate.

Authority.

Accusation.

Record.

Consequence.

Martin remained in the corridor.

"You entered my home."

"Someone entered the record."

"My daughter lives two floors below me."

"She is not part of the case."

Martin believed that sentence only enough to make it dangerous.

He stepped into the courtroom.

The door remained open behind him.

A man stood inside the observation alcove to the right of the bench.

Martin saw only part of him through the tinted glass.

Average height.

Narrow shoulders.

One hand resting beside a control panel removed from the wall.

A court-access badge hung from a black lanyard.

The photograph belonged to a woman Martin had never seen.

Borrowed credential.

Real door.

False person.

Martin lifted his phone and took three photographs.

The man did not stop him.

"Those will remain on the device," the man said.

"Then you made a mistake."

"Only if the device leaves the room before the verdict."

Martin backed towards the open door.

The green light above the storage exit went dark.

The courtroom door closed.

He turned before the latch caught and drove his shoulder into it.

The door moved two inches.

A restraint cable tightened across the gap.

Not locked.

Controlled.

Martin reached for the knife on the bench.

The man entered from the observation alcove.

No mask.

Martin saw his face.

He also saw the compact injector in the man's right hand.

He struck first.

His fist caught the man's jaw and drove him against the rail.
The injector fell. Martin reached for it, but his left knee failed
when the man kicked the inside of the joint.

The courtroom floor rose hard beneath him.

The man did not reach for the injector.

He reached for the knife.

Martin caught his wrist with both hands.

For several seconds they remained there, neither speaking,
the blade between them and the retired badge above it.

Martin had been stronger once.

The other man knew where age had changed him.

Pressure entered beneath Martin's ribs.

Not the knife.

A needle from the man's left hand.

Martin felt heat spread through his side.

His fingers lost strength before his mind did.

The man lowered him against the front of the bench.

Almost careful.

"The gun allegation is false," Martin said.

His tongue remained clear.

For the moment.

"Yes."

"Then you know this is not a verdict."

The man looked at the documents.

"It is the verdict your delay made possible."

"That is not the same thing."

"It is to the person who reads only the first true fact."

Martin tried to move his right hand towards the phone.
The man placed one shoe over it.
"My daughter knows where I am."
The lie returned.
The man did not challenge it.
"Then she will know you came to correct the record."
Martin's breathing became shallow.
The drug had not removed pain.
It had removed leverage.
The man lifted the badge from the bench and placed it
against Martin's shirt.
Not over the heart.
Over the old pocket where Martin had carried it.
The knife entered below the supporting record.
One controlled movement.
The blade withdrew.
Martin looked past the man towards the courtroom door.
It had opened again.
The corridor beyond it was empty.
The exit had always been visible.
The choice had never belonged to him.
At 4:11, the man carried Martin's phone into the corridor
and placed it beside the wall.
He deleted nothing.
At 4:13, a borrowed court credential opened the stairwell.
The building log recorded a woman who had been dead for
nine months.

At 4:15, the automatic courtroom door opened fully.

Martin Keene lay beneath his badge.

The blade rested below the record.

The first person to see him would have to decide which object explained the others.

CHAPTER 1 THE RECORD THAT ARRIVED FIRST

* * *

Elena reached the old training annex seven minutes after the first patrol unit requested Homicide.

The courtroom door was open.

She stopped before the evidence boundary and looked through it without entering.

Martin Keene lay on his back beside the judge's bench. His left arm rested across his abdomen. His right hand extended towards a black phone in the corridor, eleven feet away.

A retired police badge had been placed against his shirt.

A knife lay on the floor beneath a spread of documents.

No chair.

No watch.

No effort to reproduce Michael's earlier scenes in full.

The arrangement borrowed only what it needed.

Authority above.

A blade below.

Between them, paper.

Desai stood to Elena's right in disposable shoe covers while the scene coordinator completed the entry log.

"No one crossed after patrol saw the body," she said. "The first officer opened nothing, moved nothing and backed into the corridor. Body camera confirms."

"Who called patrol?"

"Building demolition supervisor. He received an automated door alert at 4:15 and found the courtroom open."

"Camera?"

"Local system was disconnected. One ceiling unit contains a memory card. We have not removed it."

Wells approached from the stairwell with an evidence-access report inside a clear sleeve.

"The door logged a county court credential at 4:13," he said. "Assigned to Angela Morrell. Former clerk. Died last November."

Elena looked at the false face on the printed credential record.

The access event could be genuine.

The person named by it was not.

"Any secondary record?"

"Door controller has a maintenance channel. Vendor is bringing the original service laptop. No remote query until the image is preserved."

"Good."

The medical examiner's investigator entered after the scene photographer completed the first wide series.

Dr. Lynn Park knelt beside Martin without touching the badge.

She observed lividity, skin temperature and the narrow wound beneath his lower left ribs.

"One visible penetrating injury," she said. "Minimal external blood for the apparent depth. Could be vascular, could be controlled bleeding into the body cavity. I am not calling the knife the weapon until the laboratory examines both."

"Drug?" Desai asked.

"Possible injection mark near the right flank. There is a small puncture and surrounding redness. Toxicology will take time."

Elena looked at Martin's hands.

Bruising across the right knuckles.

A split at the base of the left thumbnail.

He had resisted.

The scene did not present him as passive.

That mattered even if the killer had designed the room to make the paper more visible than the man.

The documents were photographed in place.

Page one accused Martin of planting a gun during the arrest of Darius Kemp eleven years earlier.

Page seven contained a still image from a grocery-store camera.

A handwritten note at the bottom identified the date Martin received the footage.

Three days before he disclosed it.

Page twelve contained the appellate finding.

LATE DISCLOSURE ESTABLISHED.

INTENTIONAL FABRICATION NOT ESTABLISHED.

The conclusion was not hidden.

It had been placed beneath the allegation where a reader could stop before reaching it.

"The packet contains its own correction," Elena said.

Wells remained outside the entry line.

"So did Markham's room."

"Pete wanted both versions present."

"This person may want the same."

"Or wants us to believe the same."

No one used the word copycat as a conclusion.

Pete Davidson was in continuous federal custody under plea conditions. His communications were recorded, his legal visits monitored within privilege boundaries, his physical movement documented.

The new scene occurred outside his reach.

That did not identify who had learned from him.

It also did not make every similarity his.

At 4:42, the photographer reached Martin's phone.

It remained unlocked because the screen had not fully slept. Three recent photographs showed the false seal across the courtroom door, the badge on the bench and a partial figure behind tinted glass.

The face was visible.

Not enough for immediate identification.

More than the killer had needed to leave.

"He allowed the photograph," Desai said.

"We do not know that."

"The phone was placed where patrol would find it. Nothing deleted."

"That shows preservation. Not permission. Martin may have got the image despite him."

Elena zoomed only after the technician created a forensic copy.

The figure wore a black lanyard and a county court badge.

The printed photograph belonged to Angela Morrell.

The body proportions did not.

The right edge of the image showed a wall control panel removed from its recess.

Someone had opened the maintenance channel locally.

At 5:03, the service laptop arrived inside a sealed transport case.

The vendor engineer verified the serial number against the installation contract. A federal examiner imaged the drive through a write-blocker before any controller data was read.

The hidden channel recorded one additional event.

MAINTENANCE OVERRIDE: LOCAL TOKEN 3.

The token had been issued in 2017 to a contractor supporting a police evidence-training exercise.

The assignment field was blank.

Not erased.

Never completed.

"We need the procurement file and attendance records," Wells said.

"Independent route," Elena answered. "Do not start with Michael's file because the exercise involved him. Start with the city contract."

Wells nodded.

Michael remained in federal medical custody, convicted and awaiting placement after appeal classification. The court had authorised a narrow safety-consultation protocol for the new case.

The protocol did not require Elena to use it first.

She would not let the offender create urgency that made Michael necessary before ordinary evidence had been read.

At 5:26, Rachel Keene arrived outside the annex.

She was thirty-eight, a public-school principal, and angry before anyone spoke to her.

A victim-services officer offered a private room in the mobile command unit. Rachel refused to enter until someone told her whether the badge in the leaked photograph was her father's.

The photograph had already reached two local stations.

No official image had been released.

"It appears to be his badge," Elena said. "We have not completed authentication."

"It was in his apartment."

"When did you last see it?"

"Sunday. He showed it to my son. Not like a trophy. My son asked why Grandpa was not a police officer anymore."

Rachel pressed both hands against the sides of her coat.

"What did he say?" Elena asked.

"That a badge could prove where you worked and still fail to prove you were right."

The sentence sounded prepared by years, not by the killer.

"Did he mention Darius Kemp?"

Rachel's expression changed.

"He wrote to Kemp's mother."

"Recently?"

"Three weeks ago. He wanted to apologise for holding the video."

"Did he admit planting the gun?"

"No. Because he did not plant it."

The answer came too quickly to treat as evidence and too personally to dismiss.

"How do you know?"

"I don't. Not the way a laboratory knows. I know he lied about the video for years. I know he called it a processing delay until he retired, then called it what it was. I know he was ashamed of that."

Rachel looked towards the old building.

"He was not trying to get his badge back."

"What was he trying to do?"

"Stop the worst thing he did from becoming proof of something he did not do."

Elena let the sentence remain in Rachel's language.

She did not translate it into a category.

Rachel gave written consent for investigators to secure Martin's apartment. She asked to be present after the initial safety sweep and inventory.

The warrant team agreed to preserve that request subject to scene conditions.

The apartment search began at 6:34.

Rachel waited in the hallway while the safety team cleared each room. When they allowed her inside, she did not move towards the cedar box first.

She went to the dining table.

Three envelopes lay there, each addressed in Martin's handwriting.

Darius Kemp.

Mrs. Lenora Kemp.

Cook County Conviction Integrity Unit.

None had stamps.

Martin had written the letters and stopped before surrendering control of when they would arrive.

Rachel opened none of them.

She pointed to a yellow pad beside the envelopes.

"He practised the first sentence," she said.

The top sheet contained six versions.

I am writing to correct the record.

I am writing because retirement did not end what I did.

I delayed evidence in your son's case.

I called it delay because suppression sounded intentional.

I knew the difference and used it anyway.

The final line had no revision beneath it.

Elena photographed the page under warrant and left the letters sealed.

Martin's admission to delay did not prove the planted-gun accusation.

His effort to separate them had not protected him from a person who needed the smaller truth to carry the larger lie.

Rachel stood beside the open cedar box.

The velvet impression where the badge had rested was visible beneath dust.

"He kept saying he would mail the letters after he found the original video," she said.

"Did he know where it was?"

"He believed someone from the old review unit contacted him."

"Name?"

"No. He said the person understood why a correction could still arrive as another accusation."

Elena wrote the wording exactly.

Not because it identified the caller.

Because it explained why Martin had entered the annex instead of calling police.

The offender had not offered innocence.

He had offered Martin control of the distinction he feared losing.

At 5:51, a technician found the envelope Martin had photographed on his kitchen table before leaving.

The pressure marks on the blank reverse page showed another line had once rested above it.

Under oblique light, four words became visible.

ASK WHO READS FIRST.

At 6:07, Eli Maddox arrived at the Chicago station where he worked as a crime reporter.

He had published the first story about Martin at 1:18 that afternoon.

RETIRED OFFICER LINKED TO PLANTED GUN CLAIM.

The story used authentic pages from the anonymous packet.

It did not include the appellate conclusion on page twelve.

At 3:56, after obtaining the complete order, Eli corrected the headline and added the omitted finding.

The correction went live nineteen minutes before the courtroom door opened.

At 6:12, station security isolated a courier envelope addressed to him.

Inside was a printed copy of his correction.

A red line crossed the word CORRECTION.

Beneath it lay a photograph of Eli leaving his apartment that morning.

On the back was a time.

4:15 P.M.

The time had already passed.

No one had attacked him.

At 6:19, a second envelope arrived at the federal courthouse.

It named Assistant United States Attorney Mara Quinn.

The allegation began with a true delayed disclosure, continued with a false instruction to suppress evidence and ended with a photograph of Courtroom Seven.

The door in the photograph stood open.

A new time was printed beneath it: 7:05 P.M.

Forty-six minutes away.

CHAPTER 2 THE PROSECUTOR AT SEVEN FIVE

* * *

Mara Quinn read the allegation in the presence of her attorney.

That was the first decision Elena trusted.

Not because counsel made the packet safe.

Because Mara had refused the instinct to read it alone and decide which facts other people were allowed to know.

They sat in a secure conference room two floors below Courtroom Seven. Federal Protective Service had closed the public corridor without announcing why. A bomb technician examined the envelope before the contents entered the room. Every page rested beneath a document camera so no one needed to touch it twice.

Mara was forty-nine, with short grey at both temples and the posture of someone who had spent half her life speaking while others tried to interrupt.

She did not look frightened until she reached the third page.

The case was United States v. Rowan Bell.

Fourteen years earlier.

A cooperating witness named Thomas Vale had recanted part of his statement in an email sent at 10:43 on a Friday night. Mara read the email Saturday morning and forwarded it to her trial team late Sunday afternoon.

The defence received it Monday at 7:12 a.m.

Thirty-eight hours after she first opened it.

The packet called that delay intentional suppression.

The central allegation went further.

MARA QUINN ORDERED CASE AGENT PAUL HENLEY TO DESTROY THE ORIGINAL RECANTATION RECORD.

"That did not happen," Mara said.

Her attorney, Rebecca Sloan, kept her voice level.

"State what did happen."

"I delayed sending the email."

"Why?"

Mara looked at Elena before answering.

"Because the witness had changed his story twice. I wanted to confront him before the defence used the third version."

"Was that lawful?" Elena asked.

"No. Not the delay. The email was disclosure. I knew it."

"Did Paul Henley destroy an original?"

"No. He printed it. The server retained it. The defence received both."

The packet included the server audit on page eight.

It showed the original message remained intact.

Page nine contained an internal review concluding Mara violated disclosure policy but did not direct destruction.

Again, the correction was inside the accusation.

Again, it appeared late enough for a reader to stop before reaching it.

Desai stood beside the closed door.

"Why Courtroom Seven?"

Mara looked at the photograph.

"Bell's suppression hearing was there."

"Who would know that?"

"Anyone with the docket. Anyone who read the transcript. Half the courthouse if they cared enough."

"The room is no longer used for criminal trials," Elena said. "It is scheduled for renovation."

"Then it resembles the annex."

"Physically. We are not assuming the same purpose."

The photograph showed the courtroom door open from inside.

A brass number seven.

A narrow strip of terrazzo floor.

One detail near the hinge did not belong to the courthouse.

A white evidence sticker with no number.

The same false form used at Martin Keene's scene.

Mara's attorney pointed to the final page.

"It does not instruct her to go there."

"No," Elena said.

"Then why would she be the target?"

"We do not know that she is."

Mara looked at her.

"The envelope has my name."

"A name can identify the accused person, the intended reader, the witness or the person whose decision is being tested. The first case used more than one role."

"You learned that from Thorne?"

The question contained no accusation Elena needed to answer defensively.

"We learned it from the sequence around Keene. Michael has not received this case."

Mara's shoulders lowered by less than an inch.

Not relief.

A recalculation.

"What are you asking me to do?"

"Nothing without a choice," Desai said. "We recommend temporary protection, no travel to Courtroom Seven and no direct response to the sender. You may remain here with counsel or move to a location your attorney approves."

"And the courtroom?"

"Cleared by tactical and bomb teams. Preserved as a possible scene."

"At seven five?"

"No one enters because a packet selected the time. We control the room before then."

Mara looked at the allegation again.

"Paul Henley retired in 2021."

"Current location?"

"Skokie. He teaches part-time at a criminal-justice programme."

Elena wrote the name on a separate sheet.

"Would the packet make him a witness against you?"

"If someone believed the destruction claim."

"Or a person positioned to validate it."

Mara called Henley through her attorney's phone.

No answer.

His wife answered the home line on the second attempt.

Paul had left at four to meet a former colleague near the courthouse.

He had not said which colleague.

His phone now went directly to voicemail.

The case changed shape.

Mara might be the accused subject.

Henley might be the reader.

Or the packet might use Mara's admitted delay to make Henley appear responsible for a destruction that never occurred.

"Get consent for an emergency location request," Desai said. "Separate team. Do not use Mara's office credentials to search."

The investigators moved without forcing Mara into the centre of the operation.

Her attorney remained beside her.

At 6:36, the warrant clerk approved a narrow emergency order for Henley's phone location and vehicle telematics.

The phone last connected at 5:58 near the federal courthouse.

His car entered the underground public garage at 6:02.

It had not exited.

Garage cameras showed Henley alone at the wheel.

He parked on level B3 and walked towards the elevators carrying a blue document case.

At 6:11, a maintenance camera recorded him leaving the elevator on the renovation floor.

No camera covered the corridor to Courtroom Seven.

"He went willingly," Mara said.

"He went without visible force," Elena corrected.

Mara accepted the distinction.

At 6:41, the tactical team reached the locked renovation corridor.

The main access card failed because the reader had been placed in maintenance mode.

A mechanical key opened the first fire door.

The second had been secured from inside with a cable looped through the crash bar.

The annex used the same method.

Not identical equipment.

Same decision.

Keep the door technically able to open while controlling how far.

At 6:47, the team cut the cable under shield and entered.

Courtroom Seven was empty.

No body.

No Henley.

On the prosecution table lay a blue document case matching the one in the camera image.

The latches were closed.

A white evidence sticker crossed them.

No number.

No initials.

The bomb technician examined the case remotely.

No explosive trace.

No power source.

The judge authorised controlled opening at 6:58.

Inside were three objects.

A printed copy of Mara's delayed-disclosure finding.

Paul Henley's retired federal credential.

A rubber training knife.

Not sharp.

The blade bent when the technician tested it after documentation.

Authority.

Record.

False consequence.

"Where is Paul?" Mara asked.

No one answered before there was evidence.

At 7:01, Henley's vehicle alarm activated in the garage.

The sound came through the command radio.

A second team reached the car.

The driver's door was unlocked.

Henley lay across the rear seat, breathing, with a sedative patch beneath his collar.

No stab wound.

No visible blood.

A folded page rested on his chest.

PAUL HENLEY CONFIRMED THE DESTRUCTION ORDER.

Below that sentence, in smaller type:

HE HAS NOT YET BEEN ASKED.

Henley had been turned into testimony before speaking.

The ambulance moved him under police escort to a hospital selected by his wife and attorney, not by the packet.

At 7:05, the lights inside Courtroom Seven switched on.

No one had entered.

A projector lowered from the ceiling.

The wall displayed an image transmitted through the maintenance line.

Eli Maddox sat inside his television station's legal office.

The image was live.

He did not know the camera angle existed.

A red line appeared across the correction displayed on a monitor behind him.

Then text filled the courtroom wall.

THE FIRST READER CORRECTED THE VERDICT.

THE SECOND READER WILL DECIDE WHETHER CORRECTION IS PROTECTION OR OBSTRUCTION.

The feed ended after nine seconds.

The maintenance line went silent.

Elena looked at the rubber knife inside Henley's case.

Martin Keene had received a real blade.

Henley received a false one and survived.

The difference was not mercy.

It was a message about roles.

Mara requested permission to speak with Henley after he was medically stable.

His attorney agreed to a five-minute call with no discussion of the active investigation.

The hospital placed the call on speaker while a nurse remained beside him.

Henley's voice arrived slowly.

"You did not order me to destroy it," he said before Mara could speak.

Rebecca Sloan raised one hand, warning Mara not to turn the call into testimony.

"I know what I did and did not order," Mara said. "I am asking whether you are safe."

"They put the sentence on me."

"The sentence is not your statement."

Henley breathed through the silence.

"I should have forced the email out Friday night."

"Yes," Mara said.

Her attorney looked at her.

Mara did not soften it.

"And I should have sent it when I opened it. Neither fact makes the destruction order real."

Henley began to cry without sound.

The nurse adjusted the blanket but did not end the call.

"I thought if I went to the courtroom, I could prove there was an original," he said.

"You do not have to prove my innocence by entering another room."

The sentence came too late to protect him from the first one.

It still belonged in the record.

After the call, Mara authorised disclosure of her full internal-review file to the new investigation through counsel. She did not waive unrelated privilege and did not ask prosecutors to describe the delay as harmless.

"The packet works because people will defend me by minimising what I did," she told Elena. "Do not do that."

"We won't."

"And do not let the true part become permission for the false one."

"That is the case."

At 7:12, station security found the hidden camera inside a smoke detector in Eli's legal office.

It had been installed three days earlier under a legitimate fire-inspection work order.

The work order carried the digital signature of a city inspector who had never issued it.

The contractor number belonged to Civic Review Services, a private company that scanned appellate records and maintained legacy courtroom systems.

The company had also supplied an external analyst to the 2017 police evidence-training exercise.

The analyst's name did not appear in the attendance list, only vendor code CRS-14.

Continue reading

You have reached the end of this reading sample from *The Badge and the Blade*. The complete work continues beyond this excerpt.

The Michael Thorne Series - Book Seven